

Signaling by sight

Communication is a key part of life—not just for humans, but for most wild animals, too. Keeping in contact helps animals to survive and to breed. Animals usually signal to their own kind, but messages sometimes pass between different species, particularly when one is threatening another with attack. Animal signals range from physical contact when animals meet, to beautiful and complex songs from birds and whales. But for many animals, the most important way of signaling is by sight. Using colors, movements, or facial expressions, they make sure that they get their message across.



Body language

Cowering in the snow with its ears back, a gray wolf gives way to a more dominant wolf in its pack. Its behavior is an example of body language—a kind of visual signaling found throughout the animal world. Many animals use body language with their own kind, but it can also be a lifesaver in emergencies, by making animals look bigger or more dangerous than they really are.

Mottled plumage helps female blend in with nest site on rocky ground

Male king eider duck



Spot the difference

Colors and patterns often work like an identity badge. Here, a female king eider is flanked by two males, wearing their eye-catching breeding plumage. Male ducks dress to impress, because it helps them to attract mates. They often grow their bright plumage just before the breeding season begins. Female ducks are the opposite. Most of them have camouflaged plumage, which helps them to hide while they are sitting on their eggs.

Lines of communication

Communication and senses are closely linked. Some animals can communicate by sensing vibrations or electric fields, but most send and receive signals by touch, sight, sound, or smell. Each species communicates in private by coding its signals as particular calls or scents, which helps to stop predators from homing in.



Touch

For lovebirds, touch is a way of maintaining bonds, especially between partners and between parents and their young. Animals also use touch when grooming.



Sight

With bright warning colors and its fins spread, a lion fish gives out a visual message that it has poisonous spines. Visual messages work both within and between species.



Sound

Coyotes howl to keep in touch with each other. Sound signals work on land and in water and let animals communicate even when they cannot be seen.



Smell

Driver ants follow trails by sensing a scent, or pheromone. Unlike sound, chemical messages can be long-lasting, because many pheromones take time to fade away.